

My name is Ira Shepherd Jr. I am 19 years old and I attend the University of Delaware, or UD for short. I moved from Georgia to Newark, Delaware to be able to attend the Career and Life Studies Certificate program, or CLSC.

CLSC is a two-year college program at UD. The program helps young adults with intellectual disabilities decide what they want to do with their life. I chose to go to UD because I liked the campus and the people in the program were very nice and had a very hands-on approach.

The hardest part about getting used to UD was leaving my friends and my mom and not seeing them for about six months. A lot of my friends are going to school in the South. They can go home every month, but I don't have that opportunity because Delaware is far away from Georgia.

At UD, I have taken college classes that relate to my career interests, and I also have two internships. Those two internships are at the Office of Alumni Relations and the University of Delaware's radio station, WVUD 91.3 FM. By having these amazing internship opportunities, I have been able to make connections that I never would have thought were possible.

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The first connection was thanks to the staff at CLSC. At UD's 4th Annual Disability Mentoring Day, they set me up with the radio station here at UD because I told them I was interested in a career in broadcasting. During my brief time there that day, the station manager showed me how to work the equipment and I was able to play music and broadcast it live. It made me ecstatic that the manager trusted me that quickly. The station



Ira at WVUD with station manager Steve Kramarek

manager then offered me an internship for the spring. During the internship, I learned how to work the equipment and help the radio station staff. I was also given my own show, the Ira Shepherd Show, which I have had for the last year. I play hip-hop, R&B, and other music to keep people energized through the day. I also discuss entertainment, campus news, and sports.

Before the internship started, I took a course in communications that taught me how to organize my thoughts and writing, as well as speak more professionally. During my internship, I have had to work on my voice inflection, transitions between topics and segments, and selecting the right music.

I am on the radio live from 1:00 p.m. to 2:00 p.m. every Thursday. Anyone can listen to my show by tuning in to 91.3 FM or online at www.wvud.org/

I hope to continue on into a career in sports broadcasting. I had a couple of additional experiences this past year through my connections at the radio station that have helped me learn more about this career.

First, I shadowed a broadcaster for a UD basketball game and got to ask him questions behind the scenes. Then, I was expecting to shadow a broadcaster a second time, but instead I was asked to comment on the air throughout the game! I was really nervous about this but it was too late to back out. So I tried it and ended up feeling really comfortable and enjoying it.

Next year, I am planning to take more courses in communications and radio broadcasting at Delaware Technical Community College. I will also continue doing my radio show at UD.

The other major connection I have made is with the Governor of Delaware, Jack Markell. I first met Governor Markell through my participation in Disability Mentoring Day at UD last year. I then ran into him again when he was on campus doing a television interview. When we were talking he mentioned an internship opportunity with his office.



Ira doing his live radio show
(see <http://youtu.be/MLJpjfd13FU>)



Ira with Jack Markell, Governor of Delaware

Hopefully, I will be able to do this. I believe that this internship would be a great opportunity to expand my connections and help me build professional skills that I could use later in my career.

Through the CLSC program, I have been able to take steps towards becoming a full-time undergraduate student and achieving my dreams. I would like to use the skills and knowledge that I've gained to major in sports marketing or communication. After college, I hope to become a sports broadcaster, and use what I've learned from the radio station and my classes in this profession.